

Consider theoretical approaches:

Reception theory – Stuart Hall

- The choice of presenters, guests, topics and scheduling time encodes messages about the ethos of the BBC and its commitment to provide content for a range of audiences. Some audiences will welcome a programme dedicated to pertinent issues relevant to women today, while others may question the need for such a specialised product.
- Consider possible different readings of the broadcast. What is the **intended** meaning and the **preferred reading**? What might be a **negotiated** meaning (e.g. from a male audience member)? What might be an **oppositional** response (e.g. from a sexist male listener)?

Feminist theory – Van Zoonen (A level)

Consider to what extent *Woman's Hour* achieves Van Zoonen's assertion that **gender stereotypes** in the media can only change if more women produce and appear in the media?

Feminist theory – bell hooks

Radio 4's audience is often pigeonholed as being white and middle class. bell hooks has written about how women of lower class or different ethnicity are even more oppressed by **patriarchy**. Consider how *Woman's Hour* challenges this by featuring guests and issues that reflect **diversity** in the female audience.

CONTEXTS

Social and cultural:

Consider the role of the programme in reflecting the changing roles of women in the UK over the past 70 years. *Woman's Hour* was originally broadcast in the 1940s, so it is relevant to consider how different life in the UK is for women now (possibly focusing on shifts from the 1950s housewife towards the independence of young women in the 1960s and comparing this with the present day.) Also consider the changes to a male's role in society and their representation in the media. Think about the way that audience responses to, and interpretations of, media products reflect social and cultural circumstances.

There has been a raised awareness about inequality between males and females in the media, and the BBC has made efforts to address gender imbalance. With a range of female presenters across its radio channels, some people have questioned the relevance of a show just dedicated to women. The impact of the #MeToo campaign, along with other social media campaigns highlighting sexism, and the popularity of women's podcasts show there is a diverse and engaged audience for 'women's media'. The continued production of *Woman's Hour* and the change in presenters sends a positive message to listeners about how the BBC is actively considering the way in which women are represented by the institution.

Economic

Consider how a programme like *Woman's Hour* reflects the ethos of the BBC as a public service broadcaster. Think about how the BBC's not-for-profit, licence fee-funded model influences how its products are produced, distributed and consumed by audiences.